

EMBERHOLD: IDLE LEGENDS

Free-to-Play Economy Design Document

Progression, Currency, Energy and Monetisation Systems for a Live-Plus-Idle Mobile RPG

Document Purpose

This document sets out the core economy for Emberhold: Idle Legends, a hypothetical mobile idle RPG built to demonstrate end-to-end F2P economy design. It was written as a portfolio piece to sit alongside academic research into engagement and retention, and it deliberately leans into the commercial side of that research rather than the theoretical side. Where useful I have flagged how a design choice connects back to known retention mechanics, but the focus throughout is on a system that a Live Ops or economy team could actually take into production.

The central design pillar is simple: the game should never punish a player for being offline, but it should always reward a player more for showing up. Idle progress keeps the game alive in someone's pocket. Live sessions are where the actual monetisation, mastery and social hooks sit. Every system below is built around that split.

Game Concept Summary

Element	Detail
Genre	Idle RPG with collectible heroes, base building and active dungeon/raid content
Comparable titles	Capybara Go, Idle Heroes, AFK Arena, AFK Journey
Platform	iOS and Android, free to download
Core fantasy	Building a roster of heroes who keep fighting even when you are not looking, then jumping in to push further than they could alone
Session length	Idle checks: 10-30 seconds. Live sessions: 5-15 minutes, multiple times a day
Target audience	25-45 year old mobile gamers with limited free time, mid-core leaning, comfortable spending on convenience and collection

Core Loop

The loop is built in three layers so that a player gets value whether they have ten seconds or ten minutes.

- **Idle layer:** Heroes auto-battle a current stage continuously. Resources and a passive trickle of soft currency accumulate even with the app closed, capped by an offline timer.
- **Check-in layer:** Player opens the app, collects accumulated rewards, clears the idle cap with a quick tap, and glances at anything needing attention (energy full, chest ready, guild request).

- **Live layer:** Player spends energy on active content (dungeons, arena, boss raids, events) where rewards per minute are meaningfully higher than idle, drops are visible and skill or team-building decisions matter.

This three-layer structure is what separates Emberhold from a pure clicker. The idle layer keeps churn low because nobody feels they are losing progress by closing the app. The live layer is where the actual depth, spend and retention hooks sit, because that is the content a player has to choose to engage with.

Progression Systems

Progression is split across multiple tracks that unlock at different rates so a player always has something close to completion, which is the main lever for daily return rate.

Track	Resets	Drives
Hero level and ascension	Never	Soft currency, hero XP, ascension shards
Stage progress (idle zone)	Never, only moves forward	Idle reward rate, unlocks new gear tiers
Dungeon floors (live content)	Weekly soft reset, hard cap raises monthly	Energy, gear, hard currency drip
Arena rank	Seasonal, every 14 days	Cosmetic rewards, leaderboard hard currency
Guild level	Never	Guild buffs, guild shop currency
Battle Pass tier	Seasonal, every 28 days	Pass currency, mixed soft and hard rewards, cosmetics

The stage and floor tracks are deliberately decoupled. Stage progress is what idle income is calculated against, so it can move slowly and quietly. Floor progress is gated by energy and requires an active team comp, so it is where a returning player feels they have made a decision rather than just watched a number go up.

Currency Architecture

The economy runs on a soft and hard split with one bridging currency for the Battle Pass, which keeps pass rewards from being directly purchasable with raw hard currency and protects the value of premium tiers.

Currency	Type	Primary source	Primary sink	Purchasable
Gold	Soft	Idle accrual, stage clears, hero dismissal	Hero levelling, gear upgrade, guild shop	No
Embergems	Hard	Battle Pass, events, IAP, rare chest drops	Hero summons, energy refills, ascension speed-ups	Yes

Currency	Type	Primary source	Primary sink	Purchasable
Runes	Soft, secondary	Dungeon floors, arena	Gear enchanting	No
Pass Sigils	Bridge	Live content only, never idle, never IAP	Battle Pass tier rewards	No, indirectly via XP-style accrual

Keeping Pass Sigils unobtainable from idle play or direct purchase is the single most important rule in the whole document. If a player could buy their way to the top of the pass without engaging, the pass stops doing its job, which is to pull people into daily live sessions rather than just topping up a wallet. Embergems remain the general hard currency and can be spent on convenience, but they cannot shortcut pass progression directly, only the surrounding systems like energy or summons.

Energy System

Energy gates the live layer and is the main throttle on both engagement and monetisation. It is intentionally generous enough that a free player can clear their daily content without feeling starved, but tight enough that a heavy player runs out and has a reason to either wait, use a free top-up, or spend.

Parameter	Value	Notes
Max energy	120	Roughly 4 hours of regen to fill from empty
Regen rate	1 per 2 minutes	Slower than most idle competitors on purpose, idle layer covers the gap
Cost per dungeon run	6-10 depending on floor	Scales gently so late game does not become a pure energy sink
Free daily top-up	60 energy at 6pm local time	Anchors a second daily session around evening play
Hard currency refill	50 Embergems for full bar, 3 purchases per day max	Capped to stop energy becoming the only spend
Overflow	Energy caps, does not bank past max	Encourages players to spend it rather than hoard

The 6pm free top-up is a small but deliberate Live Ops lever. It is timed to land after a typical work day, which gives a natural reason to open the app a second time without it feeling like an obligation, and it is the kind of variable that can be tuned per region once real session data comes in.

Daily Login Rewards

The login calendar runs on a 7-day repeating cycle rather than a long monthly grid. A shorter cycle means the reward curve resets often enough that missing a day does not feel catastrophic, which matters because punishing missed days too harshly is one of the more common ways F2P games quietly bleed casual players.

Day	Reward	Purpose
1	200 Gold	Low value, easy to claim, builds the habit
2	10 Energy	Nudges straight into live content same day
3	1 Common hero shard	Early taste of collection progress
4	300 Gold	Keeps soft currency flowing
5	5 Embergems	Small hard currency taste without devaluing it
6	20 Pass Sigils	Only non-live source, kept deliberately small
7	1 Rare hero shard or 50 Embergems (player choice)	Strong close to the cycle, choice adds agency

Day 7 offers a choice rather than a fixed reward, which is a small thing but it gives players a reason to think about what they actually need rather than passively tapping through a calendar. Missing a day drops a player back to wherever they were rather than back to day one, so a single missed login does not erase the whole week.

Battle Pass Structure

The pass runs on a 28-day season, which lines up with most players' natural sense of a month and gives enough runway to plan events around it. There are two tracks, Free and Premium, running in parallel on the same 60-tier ladder, plus a third Live track that only premium owners unlock and that can only be filled through active dungeon and arena play.

Tier band	Free track	Premium track	Source of XP
1-15	Gold, Runes, small Energy drops	Embergems, gear pieces, cosmetic trims	Any play, idle counts partially
16-35	Gold, hero shards (common/rare)	Hard currency, epic hero shards, avatar frame	Live content weighted 2x over idle
36-50	Gear and Rune bundles	Exclusive hero skin, large Embergem bundle	Live content weighted 3x over idle
51-60	Final Gold and Rune bundle	Limited seasonal hero, title, large cosmetic	Live content only, no idle contribution

Idle play contributes XP at the start of the pass and tapers off completely by the final band. This is the mechanism that ties the whole document together: idle play is enough to get a casual player a reasonable chunk of the free track, but anyone chasing the premium hero skin or the limited seasonal hero at tier 60 has to be putting in live sessions, because that content simply will not move without it.

Premium pass price point sits at 4.99 in local currency equivalents, with an optional Premium Plus at 9.99 that unlocks 10 instant tier skips. The skip option is capped so it cannot be used to

buy the entire pass outright, it can only compress roughly two weeks of grind into one purchase, which protects the live-session requirement at the top tiers.

Idle vs Live Reward Differential

This is the mechanic the brief specifically asked for, so it gets its own breakdown. The intent is that a player who only ever idles still has a functioning, enjoyable game, but a player who shows up gets a clearly better rate of return across every resource that matters.

Resource	Idle rate (per hour, capped)	Live rate (per hour, active session)	Differential
Gold	1,200	3,000-3,500	Roughly 2.5x to 3x
Hero shards	0.2 (rare drop chance only)	2-3 from guaranteed dungeon clears	10x or more
Gear	None below stage 80	Guaranteed per dungeon floor clear	Idle has effectively none
Embergems	None from idle accrual	Arena wins, event milestones, daily quests	Idle has effectively none
Pass Sigils	None	All sources	Idle has effectively none

Gold is the one resource idle play covers reasonably well, because Gold is the everyday currency a casual player needs just to keep levelling heroes, and locking it behind live sessions would make the idle layer feel pointless. Everything that actually moves a player's account forward in a meaningful way, gear, shards, hard currency, pass progress, is either absent from idle or present at a token rate. This is the lever that converts a passive install into a daily active session without making idle players feel cheated, since idle play was never marketed as the fast route, only the safety net.

An offline cap of 8 hours on Gold accrual reinforces the same point. A player who has not opened the app in two days does not come back to two days of banked Gold, they come back to 8 hours of it plus a small bonus chest, which keeps the incentive to actually open the app regularly rather than letting it run unattended for a week.

Monetisation Summary

Monetisation sits across four buckets, ordered roughly by expected share of revenue based on comparable titles in this genre.

1. Battle Pass and Premium Plus, recurring seasonal revenue, low pressure, high perceived value because of the live-progression gate described above.
2. Hero summon bundles and gacha pulls, the largest single spend category in most idle RPGs, priced from 0.99 for a single discounted pull up to 49.99 for a 10-pull bundle with guaranteed rare or better.
3. Energy and convenience purchases, capped daily so they support rather than replace engagement, and deliberately not the headline spend category.

4. Limited-time event bundles, tied to the live calendar described in the next section, used to monetise spikes in attention around new content drops.

No system in this document allows a player to buy outright completion of the game. Hard currency buys convenience and a better shot at collection, not guaranteed top-tier outcomes, and pass progression at the highest tiers cannot be bought past the 10-tier skip cap. That restraint is what keeps the free track of the economy credible, which in turn is what keeps free players engaged enough to be useful as opponents, guildmates and eventual converts.

Live Ops Calendar and Retention Hooks

The systems above are static, but the value of an economy like this comes from how it gets operated week to week. This section sketches the kind of recurring calendar a Live Ops team would run on top of it, written with day 1, day 7 and day 30 retention specifically in mind.

- **Daily:** Login reward, 6pm energy top-up, three rotating daily quests that feed Pass Sigils, a daily free summon token.
- **Weekly:** Guild boss event with shared damage leaderboard, arena season checkpoint, a discounted weekend-only summon bundle.
- **Monthly:** Battle Pass season turnover, a themed limited hero with its own short event track, a returning-player reactivation bundle for accounts inactive 14 days or more.

The reactivation bundle is the one piece aimed squarely at day 30 churn rather than day 1 onboarding. Idle games tend to lose players quietly once the early stage progress stalls, so a bundle that resets a chunk of energy, gives a free 10-pull and nudges the player straight back into a live session is cheap to run and tends to recover a meaningful slice of lapsed accounts in comparable titles.

KPIs to Track

Metric	Why it matters here
D1 / D7 / D30 retention	Standard baseline, but split by idle-only vs live-engaged players to check the differential is actually pulling people in
Live session frequency per DAU	Direct measure of whether the energy and pass design is converting idle accounts into active ones
Pass completion rate, free vs premium	Flags whether the live-only tiers are too punishing or correctly tuned
ARPDau and ARPPU by spend bucket	Confirms the pass and gacha buckets are performing as the primary revenue drivers
Energy cap-out rate	If too many players are hitting full energy and not spending it, the regen rate or daily content volume needs revisiting
Reactivation bundle redemption rate	Tests whether the day 30 churn hook is actually doing its job

Closing Note

The point of this document was to take an idle game premise and design an economy around it that does not just sit there generating numbers, but actively pulls players into live sessions

where the real depth, spend and social hooks live. Every currency, every reward table and every cap above was chosen with that one goal in mind: idle play keeps the lights on, live play is where the game actually happens.